

The Holy Spirit: Who He Is and What He Does

This handout is pastoral in focus — not "what is the Spirit's metaphysical nature?" but "what does the Spirit actually do, and what do we do with Him?" But we have to start with Scripture. Many of the church's debates over tongues, Spirit baptism, and spiritual gifts are heated precisely because the passages are genuinely complex. Our goal is honest exegesis — reading *out of* the text what it actually says in its historical context — rather than eisegesis, which reads modern debates *back into* ancient texts.

A note on the disagreements: people you respect, who love the same Jesus and read the same Bible, land in very different places on some of these questions. That's not a reason to avoid them. It's a reason to handle them carefully.

What All Christians Agree On About the Spirit

Before the disputes, the common ground is large.

1. The Spirit is a person, not a force.

"But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have said to you." (**John 14:26, NIV**)

He teaches. He reminds. He can be grieved (Ephesians 4:30). These are personal actions and personal responses. The Spirit is not a vague energy or a spiritual atmosphere — He is someone.

2. The Spirit is God.

Peter said, "Ananias, how is it that Satan has so filled your heart that you have lied to the Holy Spirit...? You have not lied just to human beings but to God." (**Acts 5:3-4, NIV**)

Lying to the Spirit = lying to God. Paul adds: "the Lord is the Spirit" (2 Corinthians 3:17).

3. The Spirit was active at creation.

"Now the earth was formless and empty, darkness was over the surface of the deep, and the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters." (**Genesis 1:2, NIV**)

The Hebrew *ruach Elohim* — Spirit/breath/wind of God. The word *merachephet* (hovering) is used elsewhere of a bird over its nest: brooding, nurturing, life-giving. The Spirit at creation is not an afterthought; He is present at the beginning of everything.

4. The Spirit inspired Scripture.

"For prophecy never had its origin in the human will, but prophets, though human, spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit." (**2 Peter 1:21, NIV**)

5. The Spirit convicts of sin.

"He will prove the world to be in the wrong about sin and righteousness and judgment" (John 16:8, NIV). The discomfort you feel when the Spirit is at work is not the same as guilt from human shame. It has a specific target and a specific remedy.

6. Every true believer has the Spirit.

"You, however, are not in the realm of the flesh but are in the realm of the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God lives in you. And if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, they do not belong to Christ." (**Romans 8:9, NIV**)

This is Paul's clearest statement. The Spirit's presence is not a reward for advanced Christians — it is the defining mark of belonging to Christ at all.

7. The Spirit produces fruit in believers.

"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, forbearance, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control." (**Galatians 5:22-23, NIV**)

Note: *fruit* is singular — one integrated character, not nine separate items. And it is *fruit*, not *work* — it grows; it cannot be manufactured.

I. The Spirit in the Old Testament

Understanding the Spirit's OT role sets the baseline against which the New Covenant promise becomes radical. "New" only makes sense against the background of what existed before.

The Spirit and Creation

Genesis 1:2 establishes that the Spirit is present before anything else exists. The same *ruach* — wind, breath, spirit — that hovered over formless chaos at the beginning is the one Jesus will promise will live inside His followers. The Spirit who brought order and life out of nothing is the same Spirit who brings new life to those who are spiritually dead.

The Spirit "Coming Upon" People

In the OT, the Spirit empowers specific individuals for specific tasks. The language is consistently "came upon" — not "dwelt *within*." This is the pattern throughout:

Craftsmen: Bezalel, chosen to build the Tabernacle:

"I have filled him with the Spirit of God, with wisdom, with understanding, with knowledge and with all kinds of skills." (**Exodus 31:3, NIV**)

Judges: Othniel (Judges 3:10), Gideon — "the Spirit of the LORD came on Gideon" (Judges 6:34), Samson:

"The Spirit of the LORD came powerfully upon him so that he tore the lion apart with his bare hands as he might have torn a young goat." (**Judges 14:6, NIV**)

Kings: Saul — "the Spirit of God came powerfully upon him" (1 Samuel 10:10), then:

"Now the Spirit of the LORD had departed from Saul, and an evil spirit from the LORD tormented him." (**1 Samuel 16:14, NIV**)

The Spirit's departure from Saul will come up again when we ask whether the Spirit can leave a believer under the New Covenant.

Prophets: Isaiah announces his commission:

"The Spirit of the Sovereign LORD is on me, because the LORD has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor." (**Isaiah 61:1, NIV**)

This is the verse Jesus reads in the Nazareth synagogue (Luke 4:18) and declares fulfilled in their hearing.

The pattern: The Spirit comes *upon* people, for tasks, for seasons. It is not described as permanent, universal indwelling for all of God's people. This is the baseline. And Moses articulates the longing for something more: "I wish that all the LORD's people were prophets and that the LORD would put his Spirit on them!" (Numbers 11:29, NIV). That wish becomes a promise.

The New Covenant Promise

Two OT texts explicitly promise a radical change in how the Spirit relates to God's people:

Ezekiel 36:26-27:

"I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit in you; I will remove from you your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit in you and move you to follow my decrees and be careful to keep my laws." (**Ezekiel 36:26-27, NIV**)

Three things: a new heart, a new spirit, and then — *my* Spirit. God will place His own Spirit inside His people. Not upon a few leaders for tasks, but inside every member of the covenant community, enabling obedience from the inside out.

Joel 2:28-29:

"And afterward, I will pour out my Spirit on all people. Your sons and daughters will prophesy, your old men will dream dreams, your young men will see visions. Even on my servants, both men and women, I will pour out my Spirit in those days." (**Joel 2:28-29, NIV**)

"All people" — not kings and prophets and judges. Sons *and* daughters. Old *and* young. Even servants. Joel promises the complete democratization of the Spirit — what was hierarchical and selective in the OT, the new covenant levels entirely. Peter stands up at Pentecost and declares: "This is what was spoken by the prophet Joel" (Acts 2:16).

II. Jesus and the Spirit

Conceived by the Spirit

Luke 1:35 — the angel tells Mary: "The Holy Spirit will come on you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you." The word *overshadow* (*episkiazō*) is the same Greek word used of the glory cloud overshadowing the Tabernacle. The Shekinah presence of God is at work in the conception. (The *Son of God* handout covers this in depth — here we note that Jesus's unique relationship with the Spirit begins before birth.)

Baptized — Spirit Descends

All four Gospels record this (Matthew 3:16-17; Mark 1:10-11; Luke 3:21-22; John 1:32-34):

"As soon as Jesus was baptized, he went up out of the water. At that moment heaven was opened, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and alighting on him. And a voice from heaven said, 'This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased.'" (**Matthew 3:16-17, NIV**)

John the Baptist makes a contrast: "I baptize you with water for repentance. But after me comes one who is more powerful than I... He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire" (Matthew 3:11, NIV). This contrast — John's water baptism versus Jesus's Spirit baptism — is the seed of later debates about whether these are one event or two.

Luke especially emphasizes the Spirit throughout Jesus's ministry: "full of the Holy Spirit" (Luke 4:1), "in the power of the Spirit" (Luke 4:14). Jesus's ministry is a Spirit-saturated ministry from beginning to end.

John 7:37-39 — Not Yet Given

"On the last and greatest day of the festival, Jesus stood and said in a loud voice, 'Let anyone who is thirsty come to me and drink. Whoever believes in me, as Scripture has said, rivers of living water will flow from within them.' By this he meant the Spirit, whom those who believed in him were later to receive. Up to that time the Spirit had not been given, since Jesus had not yet been glorified." (**John 7:37-39, NIV**)

John's editorial note is essential: the full experience of Spirit-indwelling was not available before the cross and resurrection. The OT pattern was still operative. Jesus's glorification — His death, resurrection, and ascension — is what opens the way for the Spirit to be given in this new, interior way. The Ezekiel promise could not be fulfilled until the atoning work was complete.

John 14-16 — The Paraclete Passages

These are Jesus's most sustained teaching on the Spirit, given the night before His crucifixion. The Greek word is *parakletos* (παράκλητος): "one called alongside to help." Translated Counselor (NIV 1984), Helper (ESV), Advocate (NET). In 1 John 2:1, the same word describes Jesus as our advocate before the Father. When Jesus says "another *parakletos*" (John 14:16), the word "another" (*allos* — another of the same kind) implies Jesus was the first. The Spirit will be to the disciples what Jesus has been — but with a difference: He will be *in* them, not just *with* them.

John 14:16-17:

"And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another advocate to help you and be with you forever — the Spirit of truth. The world cannot accept him, because it neither sees him nor knows him. But you know him, for he lives with you and will be in you." (**John 14:16-17, NIV**)

With you → in you. This is the Ezekiel 36 promise about to become reality.

John 14:26:

"But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have said to you." (**John 14:26, NIV**)

John 15:26:

"When the Advocate comes, whom I will send to you from the Father — the Spirit of truth who goes out from the Father — he will testify about me." (**John 15:26, NIV**)

John 16:7-8, 13-14:

"But very truly I tell you, it is for your good that I am going away. Unless I go away, the Advocate will not come to you; but if I go, I will send him to you. When he comes, he will prove the world to be in the wrong about sin and righteousness and judgment." (John 16:7-8, NIV)

"But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all the truth. He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears, and he will tell you what is yet to come. He will glorify me because it is from me that he will receive what he will make known to you." (John 16:13-14, NIV)

The Spirit's coming depends on Jesus's departure. The cross and resurrection had to happen first. The Spirit continues Jesus's confrontation with the world's spiritual blindness — convicting of sin (failure to believe in Jesus), righteousness (Jesus's vindication through resurrection), and judgment (the ruler of this world is already judged). And His characteristic posture: He points to Jesus, not to Himself. "He will not speak on his own." A spirit that draws attention to itself rather than to Jesus is not acting like the Holy Spirit Jesus described.

John 20:22 — "Receive the Holy Spirit"

"And with that he breathed on them and said, 'Receive the Holy Spirit.'" (John 20:22, ESV)

Jesus does this after the resurrection, before Pentecost. It is genuinely debated:

- **View 1:** This is the actual giving of the Spirit — the disciples are regenerated here, and Pentecost (Acts 2) is a subsequent empowering for mission. This supports a two-stage model.
- **View 2:** This is a prophetic symbolic act, like OT prophetic drama, pointing forward to Pentecost — the actual fulfillment comes in Acts 2.

Worth noting: John's Gospel has no ascension narrative. Luke, who does include the ascension, explicitly tells the disciples to wait in Jerusalem for the Spirit (Luke 24:49; Acts 1:4). John and Luke are telling the same story with different emphases, not contradicting each other. How this moment in John relates to Pentecost in Acts is a real exegetical question without a clean answer.

III. Pentecost and Acts — What Actually Happened?

Acts is the primary battleground for debates about Spirit baptism, tongues, and the order of salvation. It is also a *narrative* book — Luke is describing what happened. We must be careful not to assume every detail is *prescriptive* (a pattern for all Christians everywhere) rather than *descriptive* (what happened in these specific, historically unique cases).

Acts 2 — Pentecost

"When the day of Pentecost came, they were all together in one place. Suddenly a sound like the blowing of a violent wind came from heaven and filled the whole house where they were sitting. They saw what seemed to be tongues of fire that separated and came to rest on each of them. All of them were filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them." (Acts 2:1-4, NIV)

Three signs: sound of rushing wind (*pnoē* — same root as *pneuma*, Spirit/breath), tongues of fire on each person, and speaking in *heterais glōssais* — other tongues, other languages. Verses 6-11 confirm these were recognized human languages: the international crowd "each heard their own language being spoken" (*tē idia dialektō* — their own dialect). Whatever else can be said about tongues in the NT, Acts 2 tongues are real human languages understood by native speakers.

Peter stands up and quotes Joel 2: "This is what was spoken by the prophet Joel" (v.16). The new covenant promise is fulfilled. The last days have begun.

Acts 2:38:

"Peter replied, 'Repent and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins. And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.'" (Acts 2:38, NIV)

This is the most debated verse in pneumatology. Repentance and baptism are presented together; the Spirit follows. The Greek preposition *eis* before "forgiveness" can indicate purpose ("for the purpose of") or direction ("resulting in"). Whether baptism causes forgiveness or publicly declares it has been disputed for centuries. What is clear: repentance and faith in Jesus are the conditions; the Spirit is the promised result.

Acts 2:39: "The promise is for you and your children and for all who are far off — for all whom the Lord our God will call" (NIV). The Spirit is the universal Christian inheritance, not an elite experience.

The Three "Problem Cases"

Three later events in Acts present the Spirit's arrival in sequences that don't match Acts 2. Read what each actually says — do not harmonize prematurely.

Acts 8:14-17 — Samaritans:

"When the apostles in Jerusalem heard that Samaria had accepted the word of God, they sent Peter and John to Samaria. When they arrived, they prayed for the new believers there that they might receive the Holy Spirit, because the Holy Spirit had not yet come on any of them; they had simply been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. Then Peter and John placed their hands on them, and they received the Holy Spirit." (**Acts 8:14-17, NIV**)

They believed and were baptized (v.12), but the Spirit had not come on them. Why the gap? The text does not explain. Two serious proposals:

1. **Pentecostal view:** This is the normative two-stage pattern — conversion, then subsequent Spirit baptism.

2. **Historical-contextual view:** The Samaritans and Jews had four centuries of mutual hostility (going back to the Assyrian exile). A Samaritan church that arose independently of Jerusalem would have perpetuated that schism. The apostolic presence — and the Spirit visibly arriving through them — ensured the new Samaritan believers were grafted into the one body, not a parallel sect. Luke is narrating the Spirit's role in breaking down the oldest barrier in Israelite history, not establishing a universal sequence.

The text does not say the Samaritans weren't saved before Peter and John arrived. It also doesn't explain the gap. Honesty requires holding both proposals loosely.

Acts 10:44-48 — Cornelius:

"While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit came on all who heard the message. The circumcised believers who had come with Peter were astonished that the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured out even on Gentiles. For they heard them speaking in tongues and praising God. Then Peter said, 'Surely no one can stand in the way of their being baptized with water. They have received the Holy Spirit just as we have.'" (**Acts 10:44-47, NIV**)

The Spirit falls *before* water baptism, while Peter is still preaching — the reverse of Acts 2:38. These are Gentiles. Peter had to be given a vision three times to overcome his Jewish reluctance to enter a Gentile home. The Spirit's sovereign initiative made the point Peter needed to see: Gentiles receive the same Spirit, by the same faith, without circumcision or water baptism first.

Acts 19:1-6 — Ephesian Disciples:

"He asked them, 'Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?' They answered, 'No, we have not even heard that there is a Holy Spirit.' So Paul asked, 'Then what baptism did you receive?' 'John's baptism,' they replied. Paul said, 'John's baptism was a baptism of repentance. He told the people to believe in the one coming after him, that is, in Jesus.' On hearing this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. When Paul placed his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in tongues and prophesied." (**Acts 19:2-6, NIV**)

Were these men Christians before Paul's encounter? Luke calls them *mathētas* (disciples) but their knowledge was entirely pre-Pentecost — they had received only John's preparatory baptism. This appears to be a transitional case: people whose faith was genuine but whose knowledge had not yet caught up with the gospel events. Not a template for modern believers.

What Do We Do With These Four Cases?

The sequences across Acts 2, 8, 10, and 19 look like this:

- **Acts 2:** Repent → baptize → receive Spirit
- **Acts 8:** Believe → baptize → (gap) → receive Spirit (with laying on of hands)
- **Acts 10:** Hear/believe → receive Spirit → baptize
- **Acts 19:** Partial belief/baptism → re-baptize in Jesus's name → receive Spirit (with laying on of hands)

Luke is not giving us a systematic theology of Spirit reception. He is narrating the Spirit's sovereign, unpredictable movement as the gospel crosses ethnic and geographic barriers. Every "problem case" is also a barrier-crossing: Jews → Samaritans → Gentiles → pre-Pentecost disciples. The Spirit's arrival in each case is the divine endorsement of that crossing. Forcing all four into one formula is harmonization, not exegesis.

IV. The Spirit and the Believer — Paul's Letters

Paul gives us the most systematic teaching on what the Spirit actually does in and for believers. While Acts shows us the Spirit moving in history, Paul shows us what that means for everyday Christian life. If you want to understand the Holy Spirit's role in your daily walk with God, Paul is where you go.

Every Believer Has the Spirit

Romans 8:9-11:

"You, however, are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if in fact the Spirit of God dwells in you. Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to Christ. But if Christ is in you, although the body is dead because of sin, the Spirit is life because of righteousness. If the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, he who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through his Spirit who dwells in you." (**Romans 8:9-11, ESV**)

Notice something remarkable: in just three verses, Paul uses three different names for the same Spirit. He says "Spirit of God" (v.9), "Spirit of Christ" (v.9), and "Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead" (v.11). These are not three different spirits. Paul is showing us that the Holy Spirit is fully connected to the Father, the Son, and the resurrection — He is the Spirit of the one God who raised Jesus.

Now look at the sharp statement in the middle: "Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to Christ." This is not a maybe. Paul draws a straight line — if you belong to Christ, you have the Spirit. If you do not have the Spirit, you do not belong to Christ. There is no middle category of "Christian but without the Spirit."

This matters enormously for the debate about whether receiving the Spirit is a "second blessing" — a separate experience that happens after conversion. Paul's logic here leaves no room for that. The Spirit is not an upgrade you get later. Having the Spirit *is* what it means to belong to Jesus. Every believer has the Spirit from the moment they are united to Christ.

And here is the payoff: the same Spirit who raised Jesus from the dead — the most powerful act in all of history — lives in you. That resurrection power is not far away. It dwells in you right now.

Romans 8:14-17 — The Spirit of Adoption:

"For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, 'Abba! Father!' The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs — heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him." (**Romans 8:14-17, ESV**)

The word Paul uses for "adoption" is the Greek word *hyiothesia*. In the Roman world, this was a legal term. When a father formally adopted a son, that son received all the full legal rights of a natural-born child — including the right to the family inheritance. The adoption was final and could not be reversed. Paul is saying: through the Spirit, God has not just forgiven you. He has legally brought you into His family with full rights as His child.

Then Paul drops in an Aramaic word: *Abba*. This is the word a child in a Jewish family would use for their father — not distant or formal, but warm and close, something like "Dad" or "Papa." The Spirit enables you to speak to the Creator of the universe the way a child speaks to a loving father. This is not something you work up on your own. The Spirit gives you that access, that intimacy.

And then verse 16: "The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God." This is inner assurance. It is not just intellectual belief — not just knowing the right theology. The Spirit produces a deep, inner confidence that you belong to God. If you have ever had that quiet, settled sense that God is real and that you are His — that is the Spirit bearing witness.

Sealed and Guaranteed

2 Corinthians 1:21-22:

"And it is God who establishes us with you in Christ, and has anointed us, and who has also put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee." (2 Corinthians 1:21-22, ESV)

Paul stacks three images on top of each other here, and each one matters:

Anointed. In the Old Testament, anointing with oil was how someone was set apart for God's service. Kings were anointed (like David in 1 Samuel 16). Priests were anointed. Prophets were anointed. To be anointed meant God had chosen you and empowered you for a specific purpose. Paul says every believer has been anointed — not just pastors or prophets, but all of us.

Sealed. In the ancient world, a seal was pressed into wax on a document or package to show ownership and to guarantee that the contents had not been tampered with. If you saw the king's seal, you knew it belonged to the king and was under his protection. God has put His seal on you. You belong to Him, and you are secure.

Guarantee. The Greek word here is *arrabōn*, and it comes from the world of business. It means a down payment — the first installment that legally guarantees the full amount will follow. When you put a deposit on a house, you are legally committed to completing the purchase. Paul says the Holy Spirit in your heart right now is God's down payment on your full and final salvation. The Spirit is God's guarantee that what He started in you, He will absolutely finish.

Ephesians 1:13-14 — Sealed at the Moment of Belief:

"In him you also, when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit, who is the guarantee of our inheritance until we acquire possession of it, to the praise of his glory." (Ephesians 1:13-14, ESV)

The grammar matters here. The phrase "when you heard... and believed" translates a Greek aorist participle — it describes an action that happens at the same time as or just before the main verb. The main verb is "were sealed." So the sealing happens *at* the point of believing, not as a separate, later experience. You heard the gospel. You believed. You were sealed. Same moment.

Paul uses the same word — *arrabōn*, the down payment, the guarantee. He guarantees "our inheritance until we acquire possession of it." The Spirit in you right now is the first installment of everything God has promised. Heaven is not just a future hope — you already have the down payment living inside you.

This matters for the question that comes up in many churches: "Do I need a rebaptism in the Spirit? Did I miss something at conversion?" Paul's answer here is that the sealing is a one-time, completed event that happened when you first believed. You cannot be re-sealed. The seal is already in place.

But that is not the whole picture. Keep reading.

Ephesians 4:30 — Grieving Doesn't Break the Seal:

"And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption." (Ephesians 4:30, ESV)

Two things stand out here. First, the Spirit can be *grieved*. You can grieve a force, but only a person can truly be grieved. Grief is the emotion you feel when someone you love acts in a way that damages the relationship. The Holy Spirit is not an impersonal energy field. He is a Person who loves you, and your choices affect Him.

Second, notice what Paul puts right next to the grief: "by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption." Even when you grieve the Spirit, the seal holds. Grieving the Spirit does not mean losing the Spirit. The relationship is damaged, but the seal — the mark of ownership and the guarantee of your future — remains intact.

So what grieves Him? Look at the surrounding verses (Ephesians 4:25-32): lying and dishonesty (v.25), uncontrolled anger (v.26), stealing instead of honest work (v.28), corrupt speech (v.29), bitterness and slander (v.31), unforgiveness (v.32). Most of these are relational sins — ways we damage other people. The Spirit who builds community and unity is grieved when we tear it apart.

The response is not a spiritual ritual. It is repentance, reconciliation, and forgiveness: "Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you" (Ephesians 4:32, ESV).

The Spirit at Work in You

Galatians 5:16-25 — Flesh vs. Spirit:

"But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, to keep you from doing the things you want to do. But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law." (**Galatians 5:16-18, ESV**)

"Now the works of the flesh are evident: sexual immorality, impurity, sensuality, idolatry, sorcery, enmity, strife, jealousy, fits of anger, rivalries, dissensions, divisions, envy, drunkenness, orgies, and things like these. I warn you, as I warned you before, that those who do such things will not inherit the kingdom of God." (**Galatians 5:19-21, ESV**)

"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law. And those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires. If we live by the Spirit, let us also keep in step with the Spirit." (**Galatians 5:22-25, ESV**)

First, a crucial vocabulary note. When Paul says "flesh" (Greek: *sarx*), he does not mean your physical body. He is not saying your skin and bones are evil. *Sarx* in Paul's usage means the self-centered, sin-prone part of human nature — the part of you that wants to live as if God does not exist, the part that puts yourself at the center. The flesh and the Spirit are opposed to each other. They pull in opposite directions. The Christian life is lived in that tension.

Now look carefully at verses 22-23: "the fruit of the Spirit." Notice: *fruit*, singular. Not *fruits*, plural. Paul does not give us a checklist of nine separate qualities to work on one at a time. He describes one integrated character — one fruit with many expressions. Love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control — these all grow together as a package. You do not get to pick the ones you like and skip the rest.

And notice: it is *fruit*, not *work*. Fruit is not something you manufacture by effort. Fruit grows naturally when a branch is connected to the vine (see John 15). The Spirit produces this character in you as you stay connected to Christ. You do not strain to produce patience the way you strain to lift a heavy weight. You yield to the Spirit, and patience grows.

Finally: "Against such things there is no law." This is almost humorous. No legislature anywhere has ever passed a law against love, joy, or peace. The Spirit-filled life fulfills everything the law ever demanded — but it does it from the inside out, through transformation, not through rule-keeping. The law told you what to do but could never give you the power to do it. The Spirit gives you the power.

Romans 8:26-27 — The Spirit Prays When You Cannot:

"Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness. For we do not know what to pray for as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words. And he who searches hearts knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God." (**Romans 8:26-27, ESV**)

This is one of the most comforting passages in all of Scripture. Paul is brutally honest: "we do not know what to pray for as we ought." There are moments in life — grief, confusion, suffering, spiritual dryness — when you literally do not know what to say to God. You sit down to pray and nothing comes out, or what comes out feels hollow and inadequate.

Paul says: that is okay. The Spirit Himself steps in and intercedes for you "with groanings too deep for words." When you cannot find the words, the Spirit prays through you and for you. And His prayers are perfect — they are "according to the will of God."

Some in the Pentecostal and Charismatic traditions connect these "groanings" to speaking in tongues. That is an understandable connection to make, but it is worth noting that Paul does not make that connection here explicitly. He does not use the word "tongues" (*glossai*) in this passage. What he does say is something even broader and more pastorally powerful: you never have to have your prayer life "figured out." The Spirit covers what you cannot. You are never praying alone.

Be Continually Filled

Ephesians 5:18:

"And do not get drunk with wine, for that is debauchery, but be filled with the Spirit." (**Ephesians 5:18, ESV**)

This is the key verse for answering the "rebaptism" question, and the Greek grammar here is everything. The verb *plērousthe* ("be filled") has three features that all matter:

Present tense — In Greek, the present tense typically indicates ongoing, continuous, or repeated action. Paul is not describing a one-time event. He is describing something that happens again and again. You could translate it: "be continually filled" or "keep on being filled."

Passive voice — This means it is something done *to* you, not something you do to yourself. You do not fill yourself with the Spirit the way you fill a glass with water. You receive the filling. You open yourself to it. You yield to it. But the Spirit does the filling.

Imperative mood — This is a command. It is not optional. It is not just for super-spiritual people or for pastors. Every believer is commanded to be continually filled with the Spirit.

Now look at Paul's contrast: "Do not get drunk with wine... but be filled with the Spirit." Why does he compare these two things? Because both are about what *controls* you. A drunk person is controlled by alcohol — their speech, their behavior, their decision-making are all under the influence of wine. Paul says: instead of being under the influence of alcohol, be under the influence of the Spirit. Let the Spirit control your speech, your behavior, your decisions.

Here is the crucial distinction: being *filled* is not the same event as being *sealed*. The sealing (Ephesians 1:13) happened once, at conversion, and it is permanent. You cannot be re-sealed. But the filling is ongoing, repeated, and commanded. You can be filled today and need fresh filling tomorrow. The filling is not about your *status* before God (that was settled at the sealing). The filling is about your daily, moment-by-moment surrender to the Spirit's control.

Think of it like sails on a boat: the wind is already blowing. Your job is to raise the sails.

So when someone asks, "Do I need a rebaptism in the Spirit?" — that is often the wrong question. The better question is: "Am I being continually filled? Am I yielding to the Spirit's control right now, today?"

What does being filled look like? The very next verses tell us:

"...addressing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody to the Lord with your heart, giving thanks always and for everything to God the Father in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ." (**Ephesians 5:19-20, ESV**)

Three things flow from being filled: worship together in community, private worship directed toward God from the heart, and gratitude as a way of life. If you want to know whether you are being filled, check your worship life and your gratitude level.

Don't Quench the Spirit

1 Thessalonians 5:19-22:

"Do not quench the Spirit. Do not despise prophecies, but test everything; hold fast what is good. Abstain from every form of evil." (1 Thessalonians 5:19-22, ESV)

"Quench" is a fire metaphor. You quench a fire by pouring water on it or smothering it. The Spirit's activity in a community — and in your own life — can be dampened, suppressed, or ignored. You can pour cold water on what the Spirit is doing.

Notice what comes immediately after: "Do not despise prophecies." The quenching Paul is worried about may specifically be about suppressing the Spirit's prophetic activity in the gathered church. Some in the Thessalonian church may have been shutting down people who spoke prophetic words, perhaps because it was messy or uncomfortable or hard to control.

But Paul does not stop there. He immediately adds a balancing command: "but test everything; hold fast what is good." This is the biblical balance. Do not quench — do not shut things down out of fear or a desire for control. But also do not accept everything uncritically. Test it. Evaluate it. Hold on to what is genuinely from God. Let go of what is not.

This is the mature middle ground that both traditional and Charismatic believers need to hear:

- **Don't suppress the Spirit** (v. 19) — be open to what He is doing
- **Don't despise prophecies** (v. 20) — don't dismiss things just because they are unfamiliar
- **Test everything** (v. 21a) — don't accept everything uncritically just because someone claims "the Spirit told me"
- **Hold fast what is good** (v. 21b) — keep what passes the test
- **Abstain from every form of evil** (v. 22) — reject what does not

A church that quenches the Spirit becomes dead formalism — going through the motions, everything predictable, nothing alive. A church that never tests becomes chaotic and dangerous — every claim goes unchallenged, manipulation runs unchecked. The Spirit calls us to both openness and discernment. Always.

Putting It Together: Sealed Once, Filled Continually

Paul gives us two categories, and most of the confusion about the Spirit in the church today comes from mixing them up:

The once-for-all sealing at conversion (Ephesians 1:13-14; Romans 8:9). The moment you believe, the Spirit takes up residence in you. You are sealed, marked as God's own, and given the down payment of your inheritance. This cannot be repeated, undone, or upgraded. Every believer has the Spirit fully.

The ongoing, repeated filling (Ephesians 5:18). Every day — every moment — you are commanded to yield to the Spirit's control, to be freshly filled, to walk in step with Him. This is not a one-time event but a lifelong posture of surrender.

Most disputes about "Do I need a second experience with the Spirit?" can be resolved by holding these two categories clearly apart. You do not need to be re-sealed. But you absolutely need to be continually filled. The seal is about your *identity* — you belong to God. The filling is about your *experience* — you are walking under His influence. Both are real. Both matter. And Paul teaches both.

V. Does the Spirit Ever Leave a Believer?

This question matters pastorally. People who sin seriously, or feel spiritually dry, or go through dark seasons often ask: "Has God left me? Has the Spirit departed?" The answer requires looking at both Testaments carefully — because the Old Testament and New Testament actually describe different arrangements.

The OT Pattern: The Spirit Could Depart

The Spirit in the Old Testament came *upon* specific people for specific purposes — and could leave.

Saul:

"Now the Spirit of the LORD departed from Saul, and a harmful spirit from the LORD tormented him."
(1 Samuel 16:14, ESV)

Saul was chosen by God and publicly anointed — and the Spirit left him. Why? Because Saul repeatedly disobeyed God's direct commands and rejected His word (1 Samuel 15). The Spirit departed, and a tormenting spirit took His place.

Samson:

"And she said, 'The Philistines are upon you, Samson!' And he awoke from his sleep and said, 'I will go out as at other times and shake myself free.' But he did not know that the LORD had left him."
(Judges 16:20, ESV)

Samson's Nazirite vow was broken. The Spirit's empowering presence departed — and the sobering detail: *he did not even notice*. He assumed everything was the same. It wasn't.

David's prayer:

"Cast me not away from your presence, and take not your Holy Spirit from me." (Psalm 51:11, ESV)

David prays this after the adultery and murder of Uriah. He knew Saul's story and was desperate that the same thing would not happen to him. This is genuine Old Testament theology — the Spirit's presence was not guaranteed to persist through serious sin.

The honest OT conclusion: under the old arrangement, the Spirit could and did depart from individuals.

The New Covenant: A Different Promise

Now the New Testament data — and it paints a different picture.

Jesus promises a permanent Helper:

Jesus told His disciples the Spirit would be with them *forever* (John 14:16-17, discussed in Section II). Not temporarily. Not conditionally. Jesus is explicitly announcing a new arrangement — something different from the Old Testament pattern.

The Spirit defines belonging to Christ:

Paul draws a straight line: "Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to Christ" (Romans 8:9). The Spirit's presence is the very definition of being in Christ. If the Spirit could simply depart, Paul's statement becomes hollow.

Sealed with the Spirit as a guarantee:

As we saw in Section IV, the Spirit is God's *arrabōn* — His down payment guaranteeing our full inheritance (Ephesians 1:13-14; 2 Corinthians 1:22; 5:5). A guarantee that can be revoked is not a guarantee.

Grieving does not break the seal:

Even though Paul says you *can* grieve the Spirit (Ephesians 4:30), the sealing is oriented toward "the day of redemption" — a future event. The seal holds. Grieving damages fellowship but does not break the seal.

Working conclusion: The New Testament consistently presents the Spirit as the secure, permanent mark of belonging to Christ — not a reward that can be revoked by sin. The new covenant is *better* than the old (Hebrews 8:6), and one of the ways it is better is the permanence of the Spirit's indwelling:

"And I will put my Spirit in you and move you to follow my decrees and be careful to keep my laws."
(Ezekiel 36:27, NIV)

Under the old covenant, the Spirit came and went. Under the new covenant, He comes and stays.

The Hard Passage: Hebrews 6:4-6

This is the passage that troubles people most — and we need to deal with it honestly rather than explain it away.

"It is impossible for those who have once been enlightened, who have tasted the heavenly gift, who have shared in the Holy Spirit, who have tasted the goodness of the word of God and the powers of the coming age and who have fallen away, to be brought back to repentance. To their loss they are crucifying the Son of God all over again and subjecting him to public disgrace." (**Hebrews 6:4-6, NIV**)

That is strong language. Scholars across traditions have wrestled with this passage for centuries, and there are several main interpretive positions. Here they are, presented honestly:

1. Arminian view: These are genuine believers who lost their salvation.

The language is too strong for anything less. "Shared in the Holy Spirit" is full participation, not mere exposure. "Tasted the heavenly gift" and "tasted the goodness of the word of God" describe real spiritual experience, not window shopping. If these people were never truly saved, the warning loses its force — why warn people about losing something they never had?

2. Reformed view: These people had genuine spiritual exposure but were never truly born again.

They experienced real things — they were part of the covenant community, they witnessed miracles, they felt the Spirit's power at work around them. But they were never *regenerate* (born again at the deepest level). The word "tasted" (Greek: *geusamenous*, gyoo-SAH-men-oos) may imply sampling without fully receiving — just as Jesus "tasted" death (Hebrews 2:9) but did not remain dead. The word "shared" (Greek: *metochous*, meh-TOH-koos) is used elsewhere in Hebrews for varying levels of participation, not necessarily full ownership.

3. Hypothetical warning view: The passage describes something that cannot actually happen to a genuine believer.

Some Reformed theologians read this as: *if* someone could fall away after all this (which they cannot), it would be impossible to restore them. The warning is designed to keep believers on the path — like a guardrail on a bridge. The guardrail is real and serious, but a person driving properly will never go over it. The warning functions to prevent what it describes.

4. Audience-specific view: "Falling away" here means something very specific.

The letter to the Hebrews was written to Jewish Christians who were tempted to abandon their faith in Jesus and return to Judaism — back to the temple sacrifices, back to the old system. "Falling away" in this context is not ordinary sin or even a season of backsliding. It is the deliberate, public act of saying, "Jesus is not the Messiah; I reject His sacrifice and go back to animal sacrifices." That is a once-for-all decisive act of apostasy — essentially re-crucifying Christ by declaring His death meaningless.

What we can say clearly: The text does not neatly resolve the Calvinist/Arminian debate. Honest readers on both sides acknowledge the difficulty. But what Hebrews 6 does clearly say is this: apostasy — the deliberate, public rejection of Christ — is catastrophic and not easily undone. This passage is not talking about a Christian who struggles with sin, feels distant from God, or goes through a dry season. It is talking about someone who walks away entirely and publicly.

The Distinction: Grieving vs. Losing

Here is where it gets practical. There is a crucial difference between three things:

Grieving the Spirit (Ephesians 4:30) — This is real and serious. When we sin, lie, hold grudges, speak destructively, or live in ways that contradict who God made us to be, we grieve the Holy Spirit living in us. It damages the relationship. It leads to spiritual dryness. The Spirit does not leave, but His influence feels distant because we have put up walls. Think of it like a marriage where ongoing coldness and unresolved hurt creates real distance — the relationship has not ended, but the closeness is gone until the issues are addressed.

Quenching the Spirit (1 Thessalonians 5:19) — This means suppressing His promptings, ignoring His convictions, shutting down His activity in our lives and in the community. When God nudges you to speak, to give, to act, to stop — and you consistently say "no" — you are quenching the Spirit. He does not force Himself on you. He can be silenced in your experience even while He remains present.

Losing the Spirit entirely — This is what the New Testament's new covenant promises the believer does *not* experience. The seal holds. The deposit stands. The Advocate remains forever.

So what do you do when you feel spiritually dry?

If you feel distant from God, like He is absent, like prayer hits the ceiling — the New Testament's answer is *not* "the Spirit has left you." The answer is found in Ephesians 4-5: look at what is grieving Him. Is there unconfessed sin? Bitterness you are holding onto? Patterns of life that you know contradict His character? Confession and repentance restore the *experience* of fellowship. The Spirit's indwelling never actually departed.

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness." (1 John 1:9, NIV)

The fact that you are even worried about whether the Spirit has left you is, in most cases, evidence that He has not. A heart completely hardened to God does not lose sleep over God's absence. The worry itself is the Spirit at work — convicting, drawing, calling you back.

VI. Water Baptism and Spirit Baptism — Are They the Same Thing?

Depending on your church background, you might have been told these are the same event, two separate events, or that one is more important than the other. The debates here are old, and the texts are genuinely complex. Our goal is to see what the texts actually say.

The Contrast John the Baptist Makes

All four Gospels record John the Baptist drawing a sharp line between his baptism and what Jesus would do. Matthew gives us the fullest version:

"I baptize you with water for repentance, but he who is coming after me is mightier than I, whose sandals I am not worthy to carry. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire." (**Matthew 3:11, ESV**)

Mark says the same thing more briefly:

"I have baptized you with water, but he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit." (**Mark 1:8, ESV**)

Luke's account matches Matthew almost word for word:

"I baptize you with water, but he who is mightier than I is coming, the strap of whose sandals I am not worthy to untie. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire." (**Luke 3:16, ESV**)

And John's Gospel records the Baptist's testimony this way:

"I myself did not know him, but he who sent me to baptize with water said to me, 'He on whom you see the Spirit descend and remain, this is he who baptizes with the Holy Spirit.'" (**John 1:33, ESV**)

That is four out of four Gospel writers preserving this contrast. And Jesus Himself picks it up again right before His ascension:

"For John baptized with water, but you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit not many days from now." (**Acts 1:5, ESV**)

The contrast is explicit and comes from Jesus Himself. Whatever "baptism in the Spirit" means, John (and Jesus) distinguish it from water baptism. This is the starting point for the Pentecostal argument that these are two distinct events.

1 Corinthians 12:13 — The Other Key Text

Now look at what Paul says to the church in Corinth:

"For in one Spirit we were all baptized into one body—Jews or Greeks, slaves or free—and all were made to drink of one Spirit." (**1 Corinthians 12:13, ESV**)

This verse needs careful attention, because it is the single most important text for the other side of the debate.

- **"We were ALL baptized"** — Paul says this is universal. He is not describing a special experience that only some believers receive. He is including every single Corinthian Christian — and remember, these are the same Corinthians he has just spent eleven chapters criticizing for division, immaturity, lawsuits, and sexual sin. Even the most spiritually immature believers in the room have been Spirit-baptized.
- **"Into one body"** — The purpose of Spirit baptism here is incorporation into the body of Christ. The Spirit's baptizing work is what puts you *in* the church, *in* Christ. That sounds a lot like what happens at conversion, not like a later upgrade.
- **"All were made to drink of one Spirit"** — Paul doubles down. Not only were all baptized, all were given the Spirit to drink. This is shared by every believer, not reserved for the spiritually advanced.

So the question becomes: Is Paul here describing (a) a distinct Spirit-baptism event that is separate from water baptism, or (b) what actually happens spiritually *in* water baptism, or (c) the Spirit's act of incorporating someone into Christ at the moment of conversion?

The traditional and Reformed reading is option (c): Spirit baptism in 1 Corinthians 12:13 IS conversion — it is the Spirit's act of uniting you to Christ and His body. Water baptism, on this reading, is the outward sign of this inward reality.

Acts 2:38 and the Three Views

We covered Peter's Pentecost sermon in Section III — the *eis* debate over whether baptism *causes* forgiveness or *declares* it. The Greek genuinely does not settle it. This fuels three major positions:

Here are the three major positions, stated as fairly as possible:

View 1 — One Event (Traditional/Reformed)

Spirit baptism is the same thing as conversion. When you believed in Christ, the Holy Spirit baptized you into His body. That is what 1 Corinthians 12:13 describes. Water baptism is the outward, visible sign of this inward reality — important and commanded, but not a separate spiritual event. The unusual cases in Acts (the Samaritans in chapter 8 who believed but did not receive the Spirit until the apostles came; the Gentiles in chapter 10 who received the Spirit before baptism; the disciples in Ephesus in chapter 19 who had not even heard of the Holy Spirit) are exceptional circumstances during a unique transitional period, not the normal pattern for all time. The clearest statement of the norm is Paul's: "we were ALL baptized by one Spirit into one body."

Key texts: 1 Corinthians 12:13; Ephesians 1:13 ("when you believed, you were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit"); Romans 8:9 ("anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him").

View 2 — Two Distinct Events (Pentecostal/Charismatic)

Conversion and Spirit baptism are two separate experiences. You are saved (born again, forgiven, made a child of God) at one point, and then at a later point you are baptized in the Holy Spirit — an empowering experience for ministry, usually evidenced by speaking in tongues. John the Baptist's contrast between water and Spirit is the foundation: these are simply two different things. Jesus repeated the distinction in Acts 1:5. The disciples in the upper room had already been given the Spirit by Jesus (John 20:22 — "he breathed on them and said, 'Receive the Holy Spirit'"), so they were already regenerate believers. What happened at Pentecost in Acts 2 was their Spirit baptism — a subsequent empowerment. The gap in Acts 8, where the Samaritans believed but did not receive the Spirit until the apostles came, supports the idea that conversion and Spirit baptism can be separated in time.

Key texts: Matthew 3:11; Acts 1:5; Acts 2:1–4; Acts 8:14–17.

View 3 — Sacramental (Catholic, Lutheran, Some Anglican)

Water baptism itself is the vehicle through which the Holy Spirit is given. Spirit baptism and water baptism are one event, but the water is not merely a symbol — it is the means God uses to deliver forgiveness and the Spirit. Acts 2:38 is read causally: repent and be baptized *in order to receive* forgiveness and the Spirit. Jesus's words to Nicodemus point in the same direction:

"Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God." (**John 3:5, ESV**)

And Paul writes to Titus:

"He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit." (**Titus 3:5, ESV**)

On this reading, the "washing" is baptism, and it is directly tied to the Spirit's regenerating work.

Key texts: Acts 2:38; John 3:5; Titus 3:5.

What the Text Supports and What It Doesn't

We should be honest about the evidence on all sides:

- **John the Baptist's contrast is clear.** Something is different about what Jesus does with the Spirit compared to water baptism. All four Gospels preserve this, and Jesus Himself repeats it. You cannot simply collapse the two without explaining why this contrast exists.
- **1 Corinthians 12:13 equally clearly says Spirit baptism happened to ALL believers.** This makes it very difficult to describe Spirit baptism as a subsequent second experience that only some Christians receive. Paul includes every believer in Corinth — even the most immature ones.
- **The Acts cases resist a single formula** (see Section III for details). The four cases in Acts 2, 8, 10, and 19 each present a different sequence. If Acts is supposed to give us one correct order, it is remarkably inconsistent about it.
- **The one thing every view agrees on:** "Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him" (Romans 8:9). The Spirit is not a bonus feature of the Christian life — He is the Christian life. Every tradition affirms this.

A Pastoral Note

People from different traditions may have had genuine, powerful encounters with the Holy Spirit that their church calls "Spirit baptism" or "the second blessing" or "confirmation" or simply "the moment everything became real." The exegetical dispute we have walked through is about how to categorize and understand these experiences theologically — it is not about whether they are real. The Spirit moves sovereignly, and He does not always follow our theological flowcharts. What matters most is not which label you put on your experience, but whether the Spirit of God is actively at work in your life right now — convicting, transforming, empowering, and pointing you to Jesus.

VII. Speaking in Tongues — What Does Scripture Actually Say?

Few topics generate more heat in the church. Pentecostals say tongues are the initial evidence of Spirit baptism. Cessationists say the gift ended with the apostles. Most evangelicals are somewhere in between. The question deserves a careful look at what the text actually says — not what we want it to say.

Acts 2 — Tongues as Known Languages

"All of them were filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them. Now there were staying in Jerusalem God-fearing Jews from every nation under heaven. When they heard this sound, a crowd came together in bewilderment, because each one heard their own language being spoken." (**Acts 2:4-6, NIV**)

"Then how is it that each of us hears them in our native language? Parthians, Medes and Elamites; residents of Mesopotamia, Judea and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia, Phrygia and Pamphylia, Egypt and the parts of Libya near Cyrene; visitors from Rome (both Jews and converts to Judaism); Cretans and Arabs — we hear them declaring the wonders of God in our own tongues!" (**Acts 2:8-11, NIV**)

A few things to notice here:

- The Greek phrase is *heterais glōssais* — literally "other tongues" or "other languages." The word *glōssa* can mean either the physical tongue in your mouth or a language. Context tells us which — and here the context is unmistakable.
- The crowd "heard them speaking in his own language." The Greek there is *tē idia dialektō* — "their own dialect" (v. 6). These were real regional languages that native speakers recognized instantly.
- Verses 9-11 list roughly 15 specific ethnic and geographic groups — Parthians, Medes, Elamites, Mesopotamians, and so on. Luke is going out of his way to tell you: these were actual human languages.
- **The miracle at Pentecost is not mysterious ecstatic speech.** It is identifiable human languages spoken by people who had never learned them, recognized by native speakers in the crowd.

Why languages? This connects back to the Tower of Babel in Genesis 11. At Babel, humanity shared one language and used it to rebel against God, so He divided their language into many as an act of judgment — they could no longer understand each other. At Pentecost, the Spirit reverses that curse. Many languages hear the gospel simultaneously. What sin divided, the Spirit reunites. The first act of the Spirit-filled church is communication across every barrier.

1 Corinthians 12-14 — Paul's Full Treatment

This is where the real complexity lives. Paul is writing to a church in Corinth that seems to have been overvaluing tongues — treating them as a badge of spiritual superiority. He has a lot to say, and we need to walk through it carefully.

1 Corinthians 12:10 — Tongues as One Gift Among Many

In his list of spiritual gifts, Paul includes "speaking in different kinds of tongues" (*genē glōssōn* — "varieties of tongues/languages") and also "the interpretation of tongues" as a separate gift. Notice two things: tongues come in different kinds, and interpretation is its own distinct gift. You need both for tongues to be useful in a congregation.

1 Corinthians 12:28-30 — Not Everyone Gets Every Gift

Paul lists gifts in a kind of order — apostles first, then prophets, then teachers, then miracles, then healing, helping, administrating, and various kinds of tongues. Then he asks a series of rhetorical questions. In Greek, these are structured to expect the answer "No":

"Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all teachers? Do all work miracles? Do all have gifts of healing? Do all speak in tongues? Do all interpret?" (1 Corinthians 12:29-30, NIV)

The expected answer to every question is "No." No, not all are apostles. No, not all are prophets. And no — **not all speak in tongues.**

This is the decisive text on the question of tongues as "initial evidence" of Spirit baptism. Some Pentecostal traditions teach that every believer who has truly been baptized in the Spirit will speak in tongues — that tongues are the universal, required sign. But Paul explicitly says not all speak in tongues. If tongues were the universal sign of receiving the Spirit, this verse would be impossible to write. There is no exegetical escape hatch here. Paul distributes gifts differently to different believers, and tongues is one gift among many — not the gift that proves you have the Spirit.

1 Corinthians 13:1 — "Tongues of Angels"

"If I speak in the tongues of men or of angels, but do not have love, I am only a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal." (1 Corinthians 13:1, NIV)

Some people point to "tongues of angels" as evidence that some tongues are not human languages — that there is a heavenly prayer language distinct from any earthly dialect. That is possible. But it is also possible that Paul is using hyperbole to make his point about love. He follows it with "if I have the gift of prophecy and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge" — he does not actually claim to know all mysteries. He is building an exaggerated case to say: even the most spectacular gifts are worthless without love. Do not over-build a theology of angelic languages on this verse, but note it honestly — the phrase is there.

1 Corinthians 14:2 — Speaking to God, Not People

"For anyone who speaks in a tongue does not speak to people but to God. Indeed, no one understands them; they utter mysteries by the Spirit." (1 Corinthians 14:2, NIV)

This sounds different from Acts 2. At Pentecost, people understood — the whole point was that native speakers recognized their own languages. Here, "no one understands them." The speech is directed to God, not to people. What do we do with this?

There are two main ways to read it:

1. **The situational reading:** Paul is describing what happens when someone speaks in tongues without an interpreter in the Corinthian assembly. If everyone is speaking at once in languages no one present happens to know, it sounds incomprehensible. Interpretation would make it intelligible. The difference from Acts 2 is not the nature of the gift but the context — at Pentecost, the right audiences were present; in Corinth, they were not.

2. **The two-dimensions reading:** There is a congregational gift of tongues (real languages, always requiring interpretation) and also a private prayer language directed to God (which may be different in character). Some read verse 2 and verse 28 — "speak to himself and to God" — as describing this private dimension. On this view, Paul recognizes a personal devotional use of tongues that is distinct from the public, congregational gift.

Be honest: the text does not fully resolve this question. Godly scholars who love Scripture disagree here. What we can say is that Paul treats tongues-without-interpretation as unhelpful for the congregation, regardless of what is happening spiritually.

1 Corinthians 14:4-5 — Paul Affirms Tongues

"Anyone who speaks in a tongue edifies themselves, but the one who prophesies edifies the church. I would like every one of you to speak in tongues, but I would rather have you prophesy, unless someone interprets, so that the church may be edified." (1 Corinthians 14:4-5, NIV)

Do not miss this: Paul affirms tongues. He even says he wishes all of them spoke in tongues. He is not anti-tongues. But he ranks prophecy — intelligible, Spirit-directed speech that people can understand — higher for congregational use. His criterion is simple: does it build up the body? Tongues without interpretation build up the individual speaker. Prophecy builds up the whole church. Paul consistently prioritizes the community over the individual throughout this letter.

1 Corinthians 14:13-19 — Intelligibility in the Assembly

Paul insists that tongues in the assembly must be interpreted. His reasoning is practical and pastoral:

"For this reason the one who speaks in a tongue should pray that they may interpret what they say." (1 Corinthians 14:13, NIV)

"So what shall I do? I will pray with my spirit, but I will also pray with my understanding; I will sing with my spirit, but I will also sing with my understanding." (1 Corinthians 14:15, NIV)

"I thank God that I speak in tongues more than all of you. But in the church I would rather speak five intelligible words to instruct others than ten thousand words in a tongue." (1 Corinthians 14:18-19, NIV)

Notice: Paul is not dismissing tongues. He personally speaks in tongues — more than any of them. But when the church gathers, the goal is instruction, encouragement, and building each other up. Five words people can understand are worth more than ten thousand words no one can follow. This is regulation, not rejection.

1 Corinthians 14:22 — Tongues as a Sign

"Tongues, then, are a sign, not for believers but for unbelievers; prophecy, however, is not for unbelievers but for believers." (1 Corinthians 14:22, NIV)

This is one of the more difficult verses in the chapter. Paul is quoting Isaiah 28:11-12, where God warned Israel that He would speak to them through people of "foreign tongues" — meaning foreign invaders. Hearing a language you cannot understand was a sign of God's judgment, a sign that you are on the outside.

Paul applies this to the Corinthian situation: if an unbeliever walks into your assembly and everyone is speaking in uninterpreted tongues, the "sign" they receive is alienation — "these people are out of their minds" (v. 23). But if someone prophesies — speaks intelligibly about what God is doing — the unbeliever is convicted, their secrets are laid bare, and they fall down and worship (vv. 24-25). This is exegetically complex, and scholars debate the precise logic. But the practical point is clear: uninterpreted tongues push outsiders away; prophecy draws them in.

1 Corinthians 14:27-28 — Rules for the Assembly

"If anyone speaks in a tongue, two — or at the most three — should speak, one at a time, and someone must interpret. If there is no interpreter, the speaker should keep quiet in the church and speak to himself and to God." (1 Corinthians 14:27-28, NIV)

Paul gives concrete rules: no more than two or three people speaking in tongues in a single gathering, they must take turns (not all at once), and there must be an interpreter. If no interpreter is present, the tongues-speaker should be silent in the assembly — but may "speak to himself and to God." That last phrase is interesting: it suggests a private, devotional use of tongues that Paul considers legitimate even when public use is not appropriate.

1 Corinthians 14:39-40 — Paul's Summary

"Therefore, my brothers and sisters, be eager to prophesy, and do not forbid speaking in tongues. But everything should be done in a fitting and orderly way." (1 Corinthians 14:39-40, NIV)

This is Paul's bottom line. Two commands: be eager to prophesy, and do not forbid tongues. Plus one principle: order matters. Any church that forbids tongues is violating Paul's explicit instruction. Any church that allows tongues to create chaos is also violating Paul's explicit instruction. Both extremes miss the text.

The Question of Cessationism

Did the gift of tongues (and other miraculous gifts) end when the apostles died? This is one of the most debated questions in the modern church. Here are the two main positions, presented honestly.

The Cessationist View:

Cessationists believe the miraculous gifts — tongues, healing, prophecy — were given for the apostolic era only. Their purpose was to confirm the gospel message and authenticate the apostles before the New Testament was complete. Once the apostles died and Scripture was finished, these confirming signs were no longer necessary. The key text is:

"Love never fails. But where there are prophecies, they will cease; where there are tongues, they will be stilled; where there is knowledge, it will pass away. For we know in part and we prophesy in part, but when completeness comes, what is in part disappears." (1 Corinthians 13:8-10, NIV)

Cessationists identify "completeness" (the Greek word is *teleion*, meaning "the complete thing" or "the perfect") with the completed canon of Scripture. Once we had the full Bible, the partial gifts were no longer needed.

The Continuationist View:

Continuationists argue that "completeness" (*teleion*) in context does not refer to the Bible but to the end of the age — the return of Christ. Paul's very next sentence makes this hard to miss:

"For now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known." (1 Corinthians 13:12, NIV)

"Then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known" — this is not describing what happened when the New Testament canon was assembled. No one claims we now see God "face to face" or know Him fully because we have the complete Bible. This is eschatological language — it points to the final day when we stand before Christ. On this reading, the gifts continue until He returns.

To be straightforward: the continuationist reading of 1 Corinthians 13:10 is stronger exegetically. The "face to face" and "fully known" language in verse 12 is very difficult to apply to the closing of the canon, and no text explicitly says the gifts would cease before Jesus comes back. Most contemporary evangelical scholars — including many who are not Charismatic or Pentecostal — hold that the gifts remain available today, even if they are not always exercised or always exercised well.

Summary: What Paul Actually Says About Tongues

If we let Paul speak for himself, here is what he actually says:

- **Tongues are real.** Paul himself speaks in tongues — more than the Corinthians do (1 Cor 14:18). He is not theorizing. He has personal experience with this gift.
- **Not all believers speak in tongues.** Paul's rhetorical question in 1 Corinthians 12:30 — "Do all speak in tongues?" — expects the answer "No." This is not ambiguous.
- **Therefore, tongues cannot be the required evidence of Spirit baptism.** If not everyone receives tongues, tongues cannot be the universal sign of having the Spirit. The Spirit's presence is demonstrated by fruit (Gal 5:22-23) and confession that Jesus is Lord (1 Cor 12:3), not by any single gift.
- **In the congregation, tongues require interpretation.** Without an interpreter, the speaker must be silent in the assembly (1 Cor 14:27-28). Uninterpreted tongues do not build up the church.
- **There may be a private dimension to tongues** — speaking "to himself and to God" (1 Cor 14:28), uttering "mysteries by the Spirit" (1 Cor 14:2). But this is less certain and more debated than the congregational rules.
- **Paul's priority for the assembly is prophecy** — intelligible, edifying speech that builds up the body and convicts outsiders. Tongues without interpretation do neither.
- **Tongues are not a spiritual status symbol.** Using them as proof of superior spirituality contradicts Paul's entire argument in chapters 12-14: every gift matters, no gift makes you superior, and love outranks them all.
- **Do not forbid tongues** (1 Cor 14:39). Paul says this plainly. Churches that ban the practice are overriding an apostolic command.
- **But everything must be done in order** (1 Cor 14:40). Churches that allow unregulated, chaotic tongues-speaking are also overriding apostolic instruction.

The biblical position is neither "tongues prove you have the Spirit" nor "tongues ended 2,000 years ago." It is: tongues are a real gift of the Spirit, given to some but not all, regulated for the good of the body, and never to be forbidden.

VIII. The Gifts of the Spirit — What Are They For?

The Greek word is *charismata* (χαρίσματα) — gifts of grace, from *charis* (grace). They are not earned. They are not rewards for spiritual achievement. They are not signs of status. They are grace-gifts distributed by the Spirit for a purpose.

Paul's teaching in 1 Corinthians 12–14 is the most sustained treatment of spiritual gifts in the New Testament, and it has a specific problem in view: the Corinthians were using the gifts competitively, as status symbols. Some were treating certain gifts — especially tongues — as proof that they were more spiritual than others. Paul's answer reframes everything.

1 Corinthians 12 — One Body, Many Parts

The Purpose of Gifts (v. 7)

"Now to each one the manifestation of the Spirit is given for the common good." (1 Corinthians 12:7, NIV)

This is the foundation. Not "given for your own spiritual experience." Not "given to prove your spiritual status." Given for the *common good* — the community, the body. Every single gift has an outward purpose. If you are using a gift and it is only benefiting you, something has gone sideways.

The Gifts Listed (vv. 8–10)

Paul lists nine gifts:

- **Word of wisdom** — Spirit-given insight into God's will for a specific situation. Not general intelligence, but God showing someone what to do or say at the right moment.
- **Word of knowledge** — Spirit-revealed information that someone would not naturally know. God making something known for the sake of the community.
- **Faith** — Not ordinary saving faith, but extraordinary, mountain-moving trust. The kind of confidence that God will act in a specific situation, beyond what seems reasonable.
- **Gifts of healing** (*charismata iamatōn*) — Both words are plural in Greek: multiple kinds of healing gifts. This suggests variety — not one person who heals everything, but different healings given at different times.
- **Miraculous powers** (*energēmata dunameōn*) — Literally "workings of powers." Supernatural acts beyond healing — deliverances, signs, acts of divine power.
- **Prophecy** — Spirit-inspired speech that builds up, encourages, and comforts (1 Cor 14:3). Not primarily predicting the future, but speaking God's word into the present moment for the benefit of others.
- **Distinguishing between spirits** — The ability to discern what is genuinely from God and what is false spiritual activity. In a world full of competing spiritual claims, this gift protects the community.
- **Tongues** (*glōssōn*) — Speaking in unlearned languages. Whether human languages the speaker has never studied or a spiritual language, the point is that the speech is not produced by the speaker's own effort.
- **Interpretation of tongues** — Making tongues intelligible to the assembly. Without this gift, tongues in a public gathering have no outward benefit.

The Sovereignty of Distribution (v. 11)

"All these are the work of one and the same Spirit, and he distributes them to each one, just as he determines." (1 Corinthians 12:11, NIV)

The Spirit decides who gets which gifts. This is not self-selected. You do not pick your gift off a menu. Chasing after one specific gift as proof of your spirituality inverts Paul's entire point. The Spirit is sovereign. He gives what He chooses, to whom He chooses, when He chooses.

The Body Metaphor (vv. 12–27)

This is Paul's main argument, and it deserves serious attention:

"Just as a body, though one, has many parts, but all its many parts form one body, so it is with Christ. For we were all baptized by one Spirit so as to form one body — whether Jews or Gentiles, slave or free — and we were all given the one Spirit to drink." (1 Corinthians 12:12–13, NIV)

"If the foot should say, 'Because I am not a hand, I do not belong to the body,' it would not for that reason stop being part of the body... If the whole body were an eye, where would the sense of hearing be? ...But in fact God has placed the parts in the body, every one of them, just as he wanted them to be... The eye cannot say to the hand, 'I don't need you!' ...On the contrary, those parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable." (1 Corinthians 12:15–23, NIV)

The applications are direct:

- The person with the gift of service is not less Spirit-filled than the person with the gift of tongues. The foot is not less part of the body than the eye.
- The parts that seem weaker are *indispensable* (v. 22). The quiet, unspectacular gifts are not second-class. They are essential.
- If the whole body were one part, it would not be a body (v. 19). Uniformity is not unity.
- God arranged the parts *just as He wanted them to be* (v. 18). Your gift is not an accident — it is God's intentional design.

The Second Gift List (vv. 28–30)

"And God has placed in the church first of all apostles, second prophets, third teachers, then miracles, then gifts of healing, of helping, of guidance, and of different kinds of tongues. Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all teachers? Do all work miracles? Do all have gifts of healing? Do all speak in tongues? Do all interpret?" (1 Corinthians 12:28–30, NIV)

Notice the order: apostles, prophets, teachers — then miraculous powers, healing, helping, guidance, tongues. Tongues is listed last. This is not an accident. Paul is deliberately deflating the Corinthians' ranking system, where tongues sat at the top.

And then come the rhetorical questions. Every single one expects the answer "No." Do all work miracles? No. Do all heal? No. Do all speak in tongues? No. Do all interpret? No. The body needs all the different parts. No single gift is universal — that is the whole point.

The "Greater Gifts" — 1 Corinthians 12:31

"Now eagerly desire the greater gifts. And yet I will show you the most excellent way." (1 Corinthians 12:31, NIV)

This single verse is the bridge between chapters 12 and 14, and it is one of the most important statements Paul makes about the gifts.

The Greek word *zēloute* means "eagerly desire" or "zealously pursue." It is either a command (pursue the greater gifts!) or an observation (you are zealously pursuing the gifts — but let me show you something better). Either way, the phrase *ta charismata ta meizona* — "the greater gifts" — raises the obvious question: what makes a gift "greater"?

Chapter 14 gives the answer. The criterion is *edification of the body*:

"The one who prophesies is greater than the one who speaks in tongues, unless someone interprets, so that the church may be edified." (1 Corinthians 14:5b, NIV)

Greater does not mean more spectacular. Greater does not mean more dramatic. Greater means *more useful to the community*. A gift is "greater" when it builds other people up.

This means teaching, prophecy, encouragement, and wisdom may be "greater" than tongues and healing — not because they are more impressive, but precisely because they consistently build the community up. The gift that helps everyone understand God better, that comforts someone who is grieving, that gives clear direction when the church is confused — that is a "greater" gift, because it serves the body.

1 Corinthians 13 — The Hinge

This is the most famous chapter in the New Testament, and it is almost always read out of context. People read it at weddings. They put it on greeting cards. But Paul did not write it as a stand-alone poem about love in general. He wrote it as the middle section of a three-chapter argument about spiritual gifts.

What Paul is NOT saying:

- Love replaces the gifts
- The gifts are unimportant
- Chapter 13 is about romantic relationships

What Paul IS saying:

- Every gift, however spectacular, exercised without love is useless noise
- Love is not a gift — it is the character in which *all* gifts must be exercised

The Three "If...But Not Love" Examples (vv. 1-3)

"If I speak in the tongues of men or of angels, but do not have love, I am only a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal. If I have the gift of prophecy and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have a faith that can move mountains, but do not have love, I am nothing. If I give all I possess to the poor and give over my body to hardship that I may boast, but do not have love, I gain nothing." (1 Corinthians 13:1-3, NIV)

Read that again slowly. Tongues of men *and* angels — the most exalted speech imaginable — without love equals noise. Prophecy, total knowledge, mountain-moving faith — without love equals *nothing*. Even giving away everything you own, even dying for a cause — without love, you gain *nothing*.

Paul is not being dramatic for effect. He is being precise. A loveless gift is an empty gift. It does not matter how powerful it looks.

The Portrait of Love (vv. 4-7)

"Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud. It does not dishonor others, it is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, it keeps no record of wrongs. Love does not delight in evil but rejoices with the truth. It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres." (1 Corinthians 13:4-7, NIV)

Notice: Paul is not describing a feeling. Every single characteristic here is *active*. Love is patient — that is a choice. Love is kind — that is a behavior. Love does not envy — that is a discipline. Love keeps no record of wrongs — that is a decision.

Now read this list again and think about how the Corinthians were using their gifts. They were envying each other's gifts. They were boasting about their own. They were proud. They were self-seeking. Paul's portrait of love is a direct mirror held up to their gift-competition. Love is the opposite of how they were behaving.

The Permanence of Love (vv. 8-12)

"Love never fails. But where there are prophecies, they will cease; where there are tongues, they will be stilled; where there is knowledge, it will pass away. For we know in part and we prophesy in part, but when completeness comes, what is in part disappears." (1 Corinthians 13:8-10, NIV)

"For now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known." (1 Corinthians 13:12, NIV)

The gifts are temporary — they belong to this age. Love is eternal. But "temporary compared to eternity" does not mean "already ceased." The gifts are like a flashlight. They help you see in the dark. When the sun comes up, you do not need a flashlight anymore. But it is still dark right now.

The "then" in verse 12 is the eschaton — Christ's return, the moment when we see Him face to face. The gifts are "partial" knowledge for *now*, until we know fully. This is the context for "when completeness comes" (v. 10). Paul is talking about the end of the age, not the completion of the Bible. The gifts are meant for the period between Pentecost and Christ's return. (This is directly relevant to the cessationism debate — the question of whether the gifts have already stopped. Paul's own framework here places their end at the second coming, not at the closing of the canon.)

The Critical Point

Chapter 13 is not the spiritually mature Christian's escape hatch from chapters 12 and 14. Paul is not saying, "Forget about the gifts; just love each other." He is saying: your gifts without love are noisy, empty, and worthless — so get love right. *Then* go back to chapter 14 and use your gifts properly.

The very next sentence proves it:

"Follow the way of love and eagerly desire gifts of the Spirit, especially prophecy." (**1 Corinthians 14:1, NIV**)

Love *and* gifts. Not love *instead of* gifts.

Romans 12 — A Parallel Gift List

Paul lists a different set of gifts in his letter to the Romans:

"We have different gifts, according to the grace given to each of us. If your gift is prophesying, then prophecy in accordance with your faith; if it is serving, then serve; if it is teaching, then teach; if it is to encourage, then give encouragement; if it is giving, then give generously; if it is to lead, do it diligently; if it is to show mercy, do it cheerfully." (**Romans 12:6-8, NIV**)

This list overlaps partially with 1 Corinthians 12 — prophecy and teaching appear in both. But Romans 12 also includes what we might call "ordinary" gifts: serving, encouraging, giving generously, leading, showing mercy.

This is important. It means the *charismata* are not limited to spectacular phenomena. The Spirit gives gifts across the full spectrum of ministry. The person who is extraordinarily generous — that is a spiritual gift. The person who leads with unusual clarity and diligence — that is a spiritual gift. The person who shows mercy with genuine cheerfulness when everyone else is burned out — that is the Spirit at work.

The same word — *charismata*, grace-gifts — covers the entire range. There is no biblical basis for dividing the gifts into "supernatural" ones and "natural" ones, as if the Spirit is more involved in tongues than in mercy.

Ephesians 4 — Gifts for Equipping

"So Christ himself gave the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, the pastors and teachers, to equip his people for works of service, so that the body of Christ may be built up until we all reach unity in the faith and in the knowledge of the Son of God and become mature, attaining to the whole measure of the fullness of Christ." (**Ephesians 4:11-13, NIV**)

These are sometimes called the "APEST" gifts (Apostles, Prophets, Evangelists, Shepherds/Pastors, Teachers). Notice the purpose statement: *to equip His people for works of service*. The gifts are not ends in themselves. They are for equipping.

This means every leader's job is to make everyone else more capable — not to do all the ministry themselves. The pastor is not the person who does everything. The pastor is the person who equips everyone else to do the work. The teacher is not the only one who understands Scripture. The teacher is the one who helps everyone else understand it.

The goal is not a church with one impressive leader. The goal is "the body of Christ built up" — a mature community, unified in faith, growing together toward the fullness of Christ.

Synthesis: What Do We Do With the Gifts?

Putting all of Paul's teaching together, here is what emerges:

- **Discover your gifts.** You discover them by serving. You do not find your gift by taking a quiz — you find it by showing up, helping people, and paying attention to where the Spirit seems to work through you. The community around you will usually see your gifts before you do.
- **Use them for others.** "For the common good" (1 Cor 12:7) is the criterion. If your gift is only benefiting you, you are using it wrong. Every gift has an outward direction — toward the body, toward the community, toward people who need what the Spirit is doing through you.
- **Eagerly desire the gifts that build others up most.** The "greater gifts" are the ones that edify the body. Pursue those. Not the flashiest ones, not the most impressive ones — the most *helpful* ones.
- **Exercise every gift within love.** Love is not an optional add-on. It is not a nice flavor to put on top. It is the whole point. A gift without love is a clanging cymbal — loud and empty.
- **Do not rank yourself by your gifts.** The foot matters as much as the eye. The person who shows mercy matters as much as the person who prophesies. The Spirit distributed the gifts as *He* determined. Your gift is not your spiritual report card.
- **Do not dismiss others' gifts.** The hand cannot say to the eye, "I don't need you." If someone's gift looks different from yours — quieter, louder, stranger, more ordinary — that does not make it less real or less necessary. The body needs every part.
- **The goal is a mature, unified body.** Not a collection of impressive individuals. Not a talent show. Not a competition. A community where every member is equipped, every gift is exercised in love, and the whole body grows up together into Christ.

IX. What Do We DO with the Holy Spirit? — Practical Life in the Spirit

After all the theology, here is the question that matters most: what does a Spirit-filled life actually look like day to day? It gives us concrete, practical teaching — not a mystical program but a way of living.

1. You Already Have the Spirit — Act Like It

We covered this in Section IV: if you are in Christ, the Spirit is in you (Romans 8:9). He is a permanent resident — sealed, guaranteed, forever. But Paul goes further:

"Do you not know that your bodies are temples of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore honor God with your bodies." (1 Corinthians 6:19-20, NIV)

Your body is the Spirit's temple — language that echoes the Tabernacle where God's Shekinah glory dwelt. Many Christians live with what we might call "practical atheism" about the Spirit — they acknowledge Him in doctrine but live as if He isn't there.

2. Walk in the Spirit — Galatians 5:16-18, 25

"But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, to keep you from doing the things you want to do. But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law." (Galatians 5:16-18, ESV)

"If we live by the Spirit, let us also keep in step with the Spirit." (Galatians 5:25, ESV)

The Greek word *stoicheō* (stoy-KHEH-oh), translated "keep in step," is a military term — marching in rank, keeping formation. Picture soldiers in a line, matching the pace of the one leading. The Spirit has already set the pace and direction. Your job is not to figure out the route. Your job is to keep in step.

This means the Spirit-filled life is not about heroic spiritual efforts. It is about *responsiveness*:

- When the Spirit convicts — respond.
- When the Spirit illuminates Scripture — act on it.
- When the Spirit prompts a conversation or an act of service — follow through.
- When the Spirit says "stop" — stop.

The flesh resists; the Spirit leads. Choosing to follow the Spirit's lead moment by moment *is* walking in the Spirit. It is not complicated. It is just costly — because the flesh always wants to go the other direction.

3. Cultivate the Fruit — Galatians 5:22-23

We covered in Section IV why *fruit* is singular (one integrated character, not a checklist) and why it *grows* rather than being manufactured. But what does each aspect of this fruit look like in practice?

- **Love** (*agapē*): Deliberate, costly choice to act for another person's good regardless of what they deserve. Not a feeling first — a decision first, and often the feeling follows. Practice on people who are hard to love. That is where love actually becomes love.
- **Joy** (*chara*): Not happiness, which depends on circumstances. Joy is rooted in who God is and what He has done, independent of what is happening around you. Practice: give thanks in everything.

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you." (**1 Thessalonians 5:16-18, ESV**)

- **Peace** (*eirēnē*, eye-RAY-nay): Wholeness, not just the absence of conflict. It is the deep settledness that comes from trusting God. Maintained by prayer:

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus." (**Philippians 4:6-7, ESV**)

- **Patience** (*makrothumia*, mah-kro-thoo-MEE-ah): Literally "long-tempered" — the opposite of short-tempered. Slow to anger, willing to endure. It grows by being tested. There is no shortcut.
- **Kindness and Goodness**: Active doing of good. Not passive niceness, not just being pleasant. Kindness sees a need and moves toward it. Goodness does what is right even when it is not comfortable.
- **Faithfulness** (*pistis*): Reliability. Trustworthiness. Do you do what you say you will do? Do people know they can count on you? This is not glamorous, but it is deeply Christlike.
- **Gentleness** (*prautēs*, prah-OO-tace): Strength under control. This is not weakness. Moses was called the most humble (gentle) man on the face of the earth (Numbers 12:3), and he was not weak. Gentleness is power that does not need to prove itself.
- **Self-control** (*enkrateia*, en-KRAH-tay-ah): Mastery over your own appetites and desires. The opposite of being controlled by the flesh. The ability to say "no" to what is destructive and "yes" to what is life-giving.

None of these are produced by trying harder. They grow in proportion to your connection to the Spirit — through Scripture, prayer, community, and obedience. If you feel like you are white-knuckling your way through the Christian life, that is a sign you are relying on willpower instead of the Spirit. Go back to Ephesians 5:18: be filled.

4. Pray in the Spirit

Three key texts teach us about prayer and the Spirit:

When you don't know what to pray — Romans 8:26-27:

"Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness. For we do not know what to pray for as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words. And he who searches hearts knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God." (**Romans 8:26-27, ESV**)

When you sit down to pray and don't know what to say — when life is too heavy, too confusing, too painful for words — the Spirit carries what you cannot articulate. Come to God with what you have. The Spirit will translate.

Pray in the Spirit on all occasions — Ephesians 6:18:

"...praying at all times in the Spirit, with all prayer and supplication. To that end, keep alert with all perseverance, making supplication for all the saints." (**Ephesians 6:18, ESV**)

"Praying in the Spirit" is not a specific technique. It is praying in dependence on the Spirit, with the Spirit's help, from a Spirit-filled posture. Notice "all prayer and supplication" — it includes every kind of prayer. Confession, praise, intercession, lament, thanksgiving. All of it, in the Spirit.

Praying in the Spirit builds you up — Jude 20:

"But you, beloved, building yourselves up in your most holy faith and praying in the Holy Spirit..." (**Jude 20, ESV**)

Praying in the Spirit is not just asking God for things. It strengthens your faith. It is a building-up activity. If your faith feels weak, pray. Not because prayer is magic, but because in prayer you are connecting to the Spirit who sustains you.

A note on tongues: Some read "praying in the Spirit" as specifically praying in tongues. This may be included (cf. 1 Cor 14:14), but the phrase is not limited to tongues. It describes a broader reality: a Spirit-dependent posture in all prayer. Whether or not you practice tongues, you are called to pray in the Spirit.

5. Listen to the Spirit's Guidance

"When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth, for he will not speak on his own authority, but whatever he hears he will speak, and he will declare to you the things that are to come." (**John 16:13, ESV**)

"For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God." (**Romans 8:14, ESV**)

"Being led by the Spirit" in Romans 8 is not primarily about dramatic guidance experiences — hearing voices, getting signs, having visions. The immediate context is being led *away from* sin and *toward* righteousness (Romans 8:12-13). The Spirit's most consistent guidance is moral: conviction about sin, illumination of Scripture, persistent nudges toward obedience and love.

Practically, the Spirit usually speaks through:

- **Scripture** — This is the primary channel. He inspired it; He uses it. If you want to hear the Spirit, read the Bible. He will make it alive to you.
- **Conviction** — That persistent discomfort about something you're doing (or not doing) is often the Spirit. Don't ignore it.
- **Community** — Other Spirit-filled believers reflecting truth back to you. This is why isolation is spiritually dangerous.
- **Prayer** — The Spirit shapes your desires as you pray. Things you didn't care about start to matter. Things you were obsessed with start to lose their grip.

The test for claimed Spirit-guidance: How do you know if something is really from the Spirit and not just your own feelings or someone else's manipulation? Three questions:

1. Does it align with Scripture? The Spirit will never contradict what He has already said.
2. Does it produce love, not division? The Spirit's fruit is love; His work builds up.
3. Does it glorify Jesus, not the person claiming to be guided?

"He will glorify me, for he will take what is mine and declare it to you." (**John 16:14, ESV**)

If the "guidance" points people to the guide instead of to Jesus, be cautious.

6. The Spirit-Filled Community — 1 Corinthians 14:26

"What then, brothers? When you come together, each one has a hymn, a lesson, a revelation, a tongue, or an interpretation. Let all things be done for building up." (1 Corinthians 14:26, ESV)

"Each one" — this is participatory, not passive. The New Testament picture of gathered community is not one person up front doing everything while everyone else sits and consumes. Everyone brings something. The musician brings a hymn. The teacher brings a lesson. Someone shares what God has revealed to them. Someone speaks in a tongue; someone else interprets. The criterion is always the same: *does it build up?*

What does a Spirit-filled church look like in practice?

- **Everyone contributing, not just the paid staff.** The Spirit distributes gifts to every believer, not just to pastors and worship leaders. If only a few people are exercising their gifts, the body is functioning with most of its limbs tied down.
- **Gifts operating in love, not competition.** The moment spiritual gifts become about who is more gifted or more spiritual, the Spirit's purpose is being undermined. Go back and read 1 Corinthians 13 — Paul put it right in the middle of his teaching on gifts for a reason.
- **Openness to what the Spirit stirs, with discernment about what is genuinely from Him.** Not everything dramatic is from the Spirit. Not everything quiet is devoid of the Spirit. Test. Discern. Together.
- **The fruit of the Spirit visible in how people treat each other.** A church can have spectacular gifts and terrible fruit. Paul warned the Corinthians about exactly this. The real evidence of the Spirit's presence is not the volume of the gifts but the quality of the love.
- **The gifts of the Spirit active in serving the community and reaching the world.** Gifts are not for display. They are for service — building up the body and drawing the world to Jesus.

Summary: The Spirit-Filled Life in One Paragraph

You already have the Spirit if you belong to Christ. Keep being filled by yielding to Him in worship and gratitude. Walk in step with Him by responding to His lead moment by moment. Watch His fruit grow in you as you stay connected through Scripture, prayer, and community. Pray with His help, especially when you don't have the words. Listen to His guidance through the Word, through conviction, and through other believers. Don't grieve Him with relational sin — repent quickly and forgive freely. Don't quench Him out of fear — stay open, but test everything. And do all of this in community, where every member brings what the Spirit has given them, and everything is done to build each other up.

The Spirit-filled life is not a spiritual elite program for super-Christians. It is the normal Christian life. It is what you were saved into. Walk in it.

X. Holding the Disputes with Charity

The debates over tongues, Spirit baptism, and the gifts have divided sincere, Bible-loving Christians for over a century. Before you choose a camp, consider a few things:

1. **Both sides have genuine biblical arguments.** The Pentecostal reading of Acts is not ignorant; the traditional reading of Paul is not faithless. These are real exegetical disputes where scholars who know the Greek and care about the text land in different places.
2. **The divisive use of tongues is exactly what Paul warned against.** Using tongues as a spiritual status symbol — treating non-tongues-speakers as second-class Christians, or implying they haven't "really" received the Spirit — contradicts 1 Corinthians 12–14 directly and completely. Paul's entire argument in those chapters is that no gift makes you more important in the body.
3. **Cessationism is a minority position in contemporary evangelical scholarship.** The view that miraculous gifts ceased with the apostles rests on an inference from 1 Corinthians 13:10 that the text does not explicitly state. Most serious contemporary evangelical scholars — including many who are not Charismatic — hold that the gifts are available today.
4. **Experience is real; interpretation is disputed.** People from traditional backgrounds who have had what Pentecostals call a "Spirit baptism" experience — a genuine, powerful encounter with God — should not have that experience dismissed. People from Pentecostal backgrounds who have never spoken in tongues should not be told they are missing something essential. The Spirit moves sovereignly.
5. **The shared ground is enormous.** Every believer has the Spirit. The Spirit produces fruit. The Spirit empowers for witness. The Spirit gives gifts for the body's good. Love is the context in which all gifts operate. The Spirit points to Jesus. None of this is disputed.

A church that argues about tongues more than it practices love has missed Paul's point in 1 Corinthians 13 entirely.

XI. For Further Study

Both Pentecostal/Charismatic and traditional perspectives are represented intentionally; read across the divide.

The Spirit in Scripture: Michael Green, *I Believe in the Holy Spirit* (warm, readable Genesis-to-Revelation survey — good starting point); Thomas Schreiner, *New Testament Theology* (comprehensive traditional treatment, more technical)

Pentecost, Acts, and Spirit Baptism: James D.G. Dunn, *Baptism in the Holy Spirit* (foundational academic study — argues Spirit reception happens at conversion); Craig Keener, *Spirit Hermeneutics* (Pentecostal scholar argues Acts is normative for today); Gordon Fee and Douglas Stuart, *How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth* (essential chapter on interpreting Acts — descriptive vs. prescriptive); Frank Macchia, *Baptized in the Spirit* (serious Pentecostal theology of Spirit baptism as broad NT theme); John Stott, *Baptism and Fullness* (short, accessible classic — Spirit baptism at conversion, gifts available but ordered)

Gifts and Tongues: D.A. Carson, *Showing the Spirit* (careful verse-by-verse 1 Cor 12–14, respected by both sides); Gordon Fee, *God's Empowering Presence* (the academic standard on the Spirit in Paul, Pentecostal perspective); Wayne Grudem, *Systematic Theology* chs. on Spirit and gifts (continuationist Reformed); Max Turner, *The Holy Spirit and Spiritual Gifts* (balanced, fair to multiple positions); Sam Storms, *The Beginner's Guide to Spiritual Gifts* (accessible continuationist introduction)

Practical Life in the Spirit: Francis Chan, *Forgotten God* (accessible challenge to Western neglect of the Spirit — high school level); J.I. Packer, *Keep in Step with the Spirit* (thoughtful pastoral guide, traditional Reformed, warm not polemical); Gordon Fee, *Paul, the Spirit, and the People of God* (accessible version of Fee's scholarly work — argues the Spirit-filled community has been domesticated)